implanted chip?[19] At present, the smartphone is still a far more valuable surveillance tool than biometric sensors.

However, as biological knowledge increases – not least thanks to computers analyzing petabits of biometric data – under-the-skin surveillance might eventually come into its own, especially if it is linked to other monitoring tools. At that point, if biometric sensors register what happens to the heart rate and brain activity of millions of people as they watch a particular news item on their smartphones, that can teach the computer network far more than just our general political affiliation. The network could learn precisely what makes each human angry, fearful or joyful. The network could then both predict and manipulate our feelings, selling us anything it wants – be it a product, a politician or a war.[20]

THE END OF PRIVACY

In a world where humans monitored humans, privacy was the default. But in a world where computers monitor humans, it may become possible for the first time in history to completely annihilate privacy. The most extreme and well-known cases of intrusive surveillance involve either exceptional times of emergency, like the COVID-19 pandemic, or places seen as exceptional to the normal order of things, such as the Occupied Palestinian Territories, the Xinjiang Uyghur Autonomous Region in China, the region of Kashmir in India, Russian-occupied Crimea, the US–Mexico border and the Afghanistan–Pakistan borderlands. In these exceptional times and places, new surveillance technologies, combined with draconian laws and heavy police or military presence, have relentlessly monitored and controlled people's movements, actions and even feelings.[21] What is crucial to realise, though, is that AI-based surveillance systems are being deployed on an enormous scale, and not only in such 'states of exception'.[22] They are now part and parcel of normal life everywhere. The post-privacy era is taking hold in authoritarian countries ranging from Belarus to Zimbabwe,[23] as well as in democratic metropolises like London and New York.

Whether for good or ill, governments intent on combating crime, suppressing dissent or countering internal threats (real or imaginary) blanket whole territories with a ubiquitous online and offline surveillance